State of the Nation

RAJ KAMAL JHA'S UNSETTLING NEW NOVEL SQUARELY ADDRESSES CONTEMPORARY INDIAN REALITIES

Raj Kamal Jha's sixth novel is a portrait of a nation on its sickbed. *The Patient in Bed Number 12*, in Jha's now familiarly elliptical style, tells stories of people who do terrible things, or to whom terrible things are done, or both. The novel opens in an intensive care unit: "Dear Nisha, meaning night, I am infected, please keep your child away from me." The diagnosis, it appears, is terminal.

The narrator is writing to his daughter. Looming in the backdrop is the pandemic, but Covid is perhaps not the only or even most dangerous virus that afflicts India. "In the beginning," writes Jha in the brief, portentous prologue, "was the video. And the video was of our family. And the video was our family." The Biblical opening hints at the birth—no, rebirth—of a nation. Instead of the Word around, which this nation might coalesce is the picture—the picture of what we have already become.

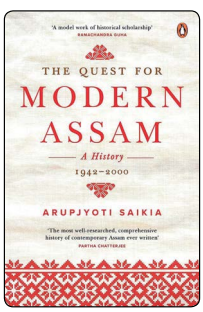
In an essay Jha wrote a couple of years ago, he dwelled briefly, as the chief editor of *The Indian Express*, on what it means to do good journalism. "This means you ask a question of yourself every day," Jha wrote. "What can I do...that most people outside the newsroom cannot or will not do? There will be many answers to that question. Let's take only one: you try to be better at listening." This, literally, is the journalist's job. To pay attention to what people say. To faithfully record what they think and feel about the lives they live. Less literally,

A WRITER'S READS



Significant Voices

Most of novelist **Anjum Hasan**'s reading in 2023 was Northeast-related



THE QUEST FOR MODERN ASSAM
A History, 1942-2000
By Arupjyoti Saikia
PENGUIN
₹1,299; 896 pages

By choice and compulsion, most of my reading this year has been Northeast-related. Among the wonderful finds has been Arupjyoti Saikia's *The Quest for Modern Assam*. This is the first book that gives the state's recent history its due and it is more than 800 pages long. Assam matters for itself and for its links to the larger history of the country, says Saikia. It's exciting to read an account that does not fall back on the usual formulation—how Assam has been side-lined post-Independence—but puts its subject centre-stage, drawing on a staggering amount of evidence from other scholarship, literature, the arts and journalism to create a highly lively and readable work.